

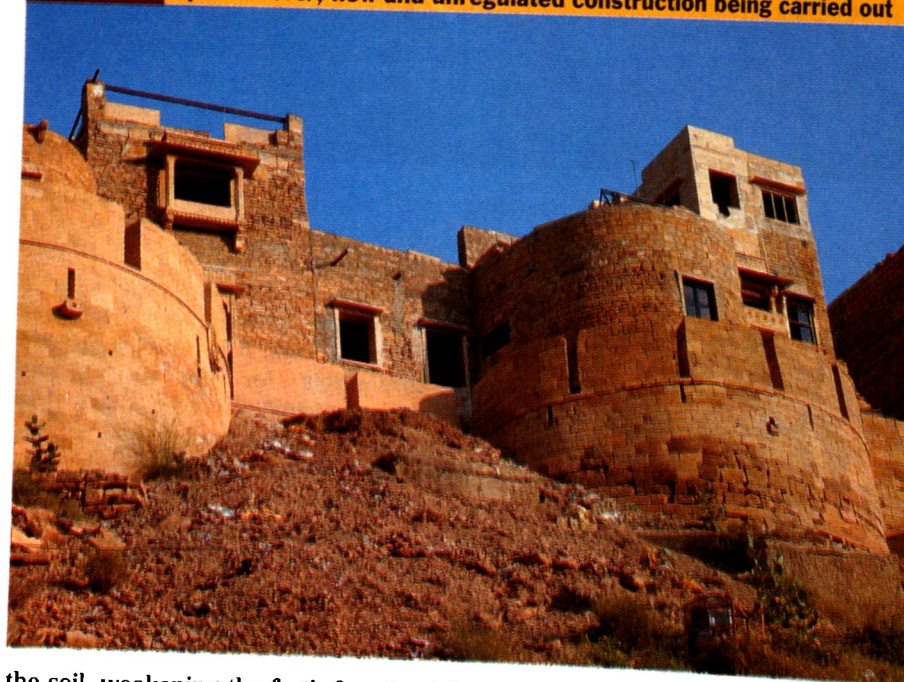
"The people of the fort are not the problem. The seepage is."

JITENDRA SINGH RATHORE, HOTELIER



NO WAY OUT

The narrow streets near the Jain temple have been encroached upon (above); new and unregulated construction being carried out



the soil, weakening the fort's foundations made of soft bentonite clay, sand and sandstone—bentonite has a property of crumbling when it comes in contact with water. Rising rainfall hasn't helped—the amount of precipitation in 1994 was 144 mm, which went up to 166 mm in 1999. Thanks to Jij's Streetscape Project, implemented by INTACH, toilets have been provided to the families living there, which have

been connected, correctly, to the main sewerage line. This has eased the lives of the families living there but paradoxically also put more pressure on the infrastructure, which was not designed for modern living. Only 20 per cent of the water supplied to Jaisalmer is acquired from the Indira Gandhi Canal, while the rest is obtained from tubewells tapping into ground water, pushing the system to the brink.

This is not the first time that efforts have been made to save the fort. In 2003, the ministry of tourism and culture signed a Rs 10-crore MoU with the World Monuments Fund, New York. At that point, the then urban development minister Jagmohan had said the fort had suffered damage due to excessive water intrusion. The work was divided in two phases and by now all the conservation work was to be completed—which has not been done, though the ongoing GSI study is part of that project.

What is the solution? The citizens believe the ASI has to give them realistic guidelines, ones that acknowledge that the fort is their home and livelihood rather than approach it in a totalitarian fashion. ASI maintains there is not enough cooperation from the inhabitants. But as Jaisalmer hotelier Chandrashekhar Shripat says: "The fort is our life and our living. If that goes, we all go." Like other proud residents of the only living fort in the world, he doesn't think commercialisation is to blame. "The tourist season is limited to three or four months. The main problem is the absence of a good sewage system," a thought echoed by district collector Vinod Pandya who says the leakages have been identified at several points. Now it is only a matter of fixing it.

But ASI believes that even if the problem of the sewage system is tackled, there will be no easing of the load on the fort's foundations and walls unless the level of development within the fort is not halted. With such mutually antagonistic parties, conservation architect Radhika Dhumal, who has lived and worked in the fort for two years, believes the only solution is a unified vision which is doable as well. Only then will the glitter of the *sonar kella* be restored.

with Vimal Bhatia and Rohit Parihar